



How **AI** and **Open Source** Can be Your Best Hope in Preventing or Containing Pandemics

The COVID-19 outbreak has rocked the globe, with many countries going into a complete lockdown. This article takes a look at how AI can be humanity's best hope in containing the pandemic as well as preventing and containing such outbreaks in the future.

The COVID-19 virus has affected the entire world in a profound way. For the first time in living memory, most of the airports in the world are shut and many countries are in a state of a complete lockdown. While the death toll from the virus may not be as disastrous yet, as compared to previous epidemics and pandemics, the sheer number of infected people is staggering. At the time of writing this article, over 580,000 people have

been infected by the disease. Over 26,000 people have lost their lives. In Italy alone, over 9000 people have died. Over 100,000 people have been infected in the USA making it the worst hit in terms of the number of COVID-19 cases. Scientists predict that it is going to take a few more weeks for the disease to peak in most countries. This could possibly mean that the numbers quoted above will only increase in the coming days, reaching new heights, before they start to fall.

Why AI was not very effective in preventing COVID-19 from turning into a pandemic

A huge number of AI projects, both open source and proprietary, have been focused on revolutionising the medical industry for quite a few years now — be it diagnosing a disease, building smarter testing equipment or creating smarter mechanisms for delivering medical aid to places the medics might find difficult to reach.

